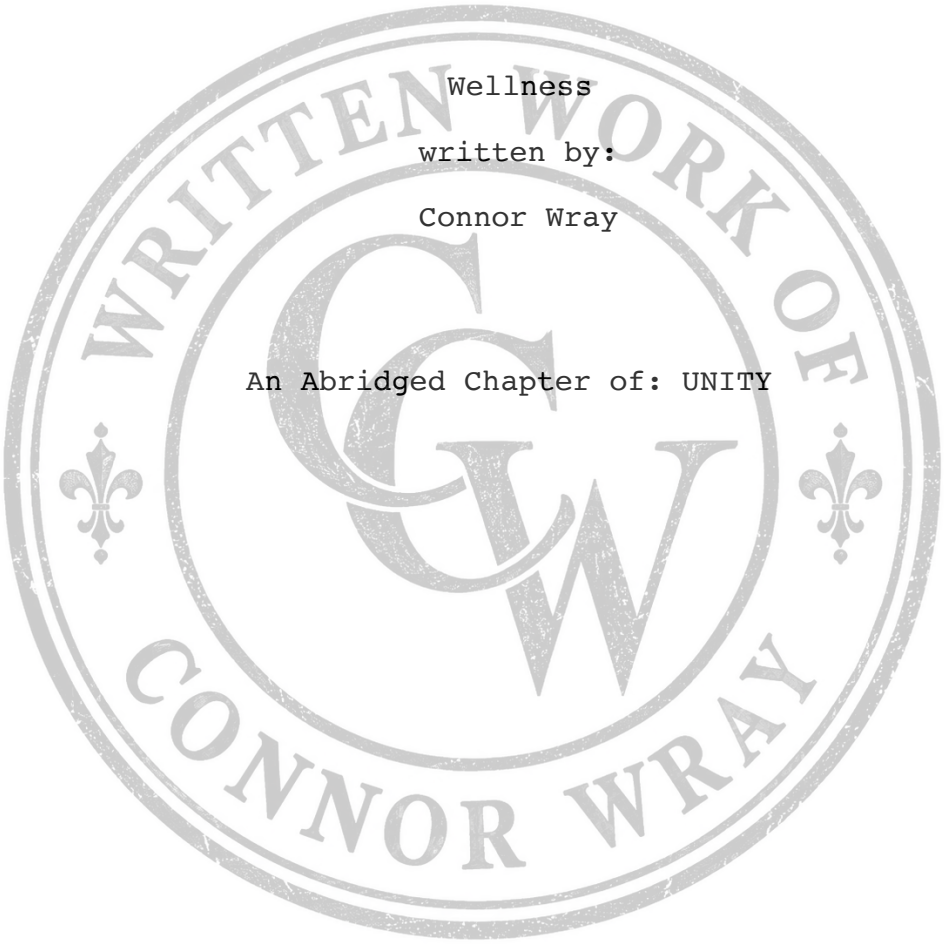
Wellness

written by:

Connor Wray

An Abridged Chapter of: UNITY



INT. HARKER'S OFFICE

CLOSE UP: A clock ticks to 2:00.

CLOSE UP: A large, beautiful painting in an elegant frame. We see no texture of brush stroke. There is an OLIVE AI system next to it on the wall.

JOHN is staring at this painting through squinted eyes as he sits in a comfortable chair. He is wearing a clean black turtleneck, black pants, white socks, and black shoes.

The office is painted dark green and is decorated in various plants and modern art furnishings.

HARKER
John?

John's attention is pulled away from the painting and to a man sitting on a chair across from him - HARKER. A man wearing a suit, tie and glasses that look like they are from the 70's.

He has a pad of paper and pen on his lap.

HARKER
Are you with us?

JOHN
Yes. Sorry Dr. Harker, I just got distracted. Is that painting real?

HARKER
You look tired. Did you sleep well?

JOHN
I slept alright, I guess. I'm still adjusting to my new room. It's weird not sleeping in my house, you know?

HARKER
That's perfectly normal, adjusting to Wellness housing takes some time. You'll settle in after a while.

JOHN
(hopefully)
Not too long I hope.

Harker responds with an almost mocking grin.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

HARKER
Let's get to it then. How are you feeling? Two days at Wellness isn't much time for improvement but even a little progress is still progress.

JOHN
It's been three days.

HARKER
I'm sorry?

JOHN
You said I've been at Wellness for two days but this is day three. I arrived Tuesday -

HARKER
You arrived Tuesday, were shown to your room, given the tour, had your first session with me, and went to bed. Wednesday you had pancakes for breakfast, had your first group yoga session, had your second session with me, at the end I gave you a little booklet. Do you remember?

John remembers, but not quite like that.

JOHN
Yes..? The one with the breathing exercises.

HARKER
That's the one. And that would make today Thursday.

Beat.

JOHN
Yes.

HARKER
So then - how are you feeling?

JOHN
Well, tired, like you said. I feel good though. We had acai bowls this morning. I liked yoga the other day, more the community than all the bending but still.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONOR WRAY

HARKER
Have you tried any of the breathing exercises yet?

JOHN
Some. Not many.

HARKER
And?

JOHN
I feel...even? I don't know if that makes sense. Before I do them my head feels light and my body feels achey but afterwards everything feels good. Balanced.

HARKER
(nodding)
Balanced is good.

JOHN
Yeah.

HARKER
How do you feel about your job?

John is uncomfortable.

JOHN
I...realize that what I did was out of line.

HARKER
(checking notes)
You told the assistant principle to "kill himself".

JOHN
I did. I had accumulated vacation days and I was going to use them to take care of my kids. They wouldn't let me use them for...I don't know why. I was frustrated and upset.

HARKER
While that's understandable...it's also unnaceptable.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JOHN
(cutting in)
I know, The more I think about it the worse I-

HARKER
(finishing his sentence)
You simply never speak to a superior that way.

Beat.

JOHN
I understand that that's part of it, I guess. But I felt that what I said was more out of line than who I was saying it to.

HARKER
(shrugging off the statement)
Sure.

JOHN
I-

HARKER
(interrupting)
How do you feel about trying another exercise?

JOHN
Fine, I suppose.

HARKER
Sit up straight, please.

John readjusts himself.

JOHN
What's the exercise?

HARKER
Are you familiar with assosiation tests? I say a word, you say a different word that comes to mind first - I show you an image, you tell me what you see.

JOHN
Yeah, like a roarshach test.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

HARKER
Precisely.

JOHN
Sure, I'm open to trying that.

HARKER
Lovely.

Harker picks a leather briefcase up and sets it on his lap. He opens it up and pulls out two identical files. He sets them both on the table before them.

HARKER
Pick one, please.

John picks the one on his right. Harker picks it up and opens it. It's various black and white images - some of places/things and some of roarshach blobs.

Harker gets ready to pull out the first picture but hesitates.

HARKER
Are you ready?

JOHN
Yes.

HARKER
(sternly)
Are you sure?

JOHN
Yes?

HARKER
Wonderful.

Harker pulls out the first image. A roarshach blob.

HARKER
What do you see?

JOHN
Small bird. Like a cardinal or finch.

HARKER
Cardinal or finch?

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JOHN
Cardinal?

Harker puts the image away, writes in his notebook, and pulls out another image. It's a distorted picture of a house.

HARKER
What do you see?

JOHN
I think that's a house. Maybe a condo?

HARKER
John, it would really help me help you if you wouldn't flounder so much. I need a single certain answer from you, please.

JOHN
(sheepishly)
Of course, sorry Dr. Harker.

HARKER
I'm not mad at you. I'm just a little disappointed.

John is clearly uncomfortable by this but Harker doesn't seem to mind or notice. Harker picks out a different picture. Another roarshach.

HARKER
What do you see?

JOHN
A very curly head of hair.

Harker writes in his notebook and picks out another picture. The number 92.

HARKER
What do you see?

JOHN
Is this a trick question?

HARKER
John, a simple answer will do. If you keep interrupting the exercise we'll need to end early.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONOR WRAY

JOHN
I see the number 92.

Harker writes in his notebook and pulls out a picture. It is of an "obelisk". The greek punctuation.

HARKER
What is this?

JOHN
Looks like a dagger.

HARKER
It does a bit, it's actually also known to be called that on occasion.

Beat.

John is waiting for Harker to pull out a different image but he doesn't.

HARKER
What is it, John?

JOHN
A dagger.

HARKER
No, that's what you said it looks like. And I agreed with you. But that's not it's real name.

JOHN
Um...knife then.

HARKER
(writing in notebook)
You said knife? Synonymous with dagger, yes?

JOHN
Usually.

HARKER
Interesting. And wrong. Try again.

JOHN
I really don't know.

HARKER
You don't know?

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JOHN
No, I'm sorry.

HARKER
I see.

Harker holds the image up for a bit longer and then puts it away.

HARKER
Moving on then...

INT. HARKER'S OFFICE

23:59:00 LATER

23:59:01 LATER

23:59:02 LATER

23:59:03 LATER...

A SERIES OF CLOSE UP SHOTS:

Clock ticking closer to 2:00.

Coffee pouring into Harker's cup.

Words in Harker's notebook: "Curious" "ADHD" and circled - "Confused".

Harker tucking a recording device into a beautiful potted plant on in the center of the table.

HARKER
(speaking to plant)
Session 4 with patient 92.

Harker sitting in his chair.

Harker perfectly aligning his coffee and the two files on the table.

Harker flipping to a fresh page in his notebook.

Harker sits perfectly still and waits patiently.

23:59:50 LATER

23:59:51 LATER

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

etc.

24:00:00 LATER - CLOSE UP ON CLOCK HITTING 2:00.

John enters.

JOHN
Afternoon, Dr. Harker.

HARKER
Afternoon, John. How was your day?

JOHN
Fine, I guess.

HARKER
Fine?

JOHN
Yeah, nothing really bad happened, you know? Just in a funk I guess. Breakfast was nice, there were omelettes and bacon.

HARKER
You do love bacon, don't you?

JOHN
(laughing a bit)
Yeah, I do...Did I tell you that?

HARKER
You must have. Go on, tell me about the rest of the day.

JOHN
I mean there wasn't much else...

HARKER
John, I can't help you if you don't talk to me.

JOHN
I picked out a book from the library. "Clone World" some science-fiction thriller piece from the 80's. It's so stupid but...I guess I like it. We didn't do much in yoga today either but it felt tedious. I've just been really apathetic today and I don't know why.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

HARKER
Apathy is a powerful thing. It affects everyone and everyone reacts differently. Some people power through it and get the job done, like the people working here at Wellness, and some people submit to it and let themselves be...well, useless. And in some cases detrimental to others. Unfortunately, like some of the patients here at Wellness.

JOHN
Jesus, that's pretty insensitive.

HARKER
I did say "unfortunately". Which end are you feeling more drawn towards, John? Persistence or submission?

JOHN
I don't know. It's not really uncommon for me to feel like this, but usually just waiting it out, getting little tasks done throughout the day and getting a good nights sleep at the end of the day fixes it.

HARKER
Are you having any suicidal thoughts?

John is taken off guard by this question.

JOHN
No, not really.

HARKER
Which is it, no or not really?

JOHN
Is there a difference?

HARKER
Answer the question, please.

JOHN
No.

HARKER
Well, that's good to hear. Have you thought any more about the events that

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

brought you here in the first place?

JOHN
Yelling at principle Hart? Yeah. I'm trying not to let it eat away at me but it's hard because I wish I had kept composure and talked it out with her. You know, I just want to apologize but without electronics or anything allowed there's not really any way for me to.

HARKER
You're feeling resentment for your outburst?

JOHN
I am.

HARKER
Have you ever burned a letter?

JOHN
I don't understand.

HARKER
It's a practice for people who are frequently put in frustrating or upsetting situations. People who have anger problems.

JOHN
I don't think I have anger problems.

HARKER
I'm not done talking.

John is shut down again, he's uncomfortable being called out.

HARKER
These people will write letters or emails or some kind of message to the person or people they believe to be the cause of their suffering. Once they get all of their thoughts written out, you simply throw it away. Delete it, burn it, whatever you'd like.

JOHN
You think I should do that?

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

HARKER
Perhaps, but that takes time. I want to try something similar and potentially even more effective. Talk to me like I'm principle Hart. What would you tell me?

JOHN
I don't know if I'm comfortable with that, I could just write a letter in my journal tonight and bring it to you tomorrow. We could destroy it then.

HARKER
We could, but this will bring about more immediate results. Try.

Beat.

HARKER
(as Hart)
John, what brings you here? What would you like to talk to me about?

John hesitates but feels obligated to continue.

JOHN
Hello..."principle Hart". I really wanted to talk...to you. I've been feeling really bad since we last spoke.

HARKER
(as Hart)
Since you yelled at me and told me to kill myself?

JOHN
Yes. I wanted to apologize...profusely. I was not in a good place mentally or emotionally and I took it out on you. It was unprofessional and it was very unkind. I can't tell you how sorry I am, and I hope you'll be understanding. I hope I'll be able to make it up to you in time.

HARKER
(as Hart)
What if I had, John?

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JOHN
What?

HARKER
(as Hart)
What if I did kill myself? Perhaps I thought it was a good idea and your words of encouragement were all I needed to follow through. What would happen to you then?

John doesn't reply. He's not participating in this weird game.

HARKER
(as Hart)
Would you kill yourself too? To atone?

JOHN
Dr. Harker I'm really not comfortable with this exercise.

Harker nods and writes in his notebook.

HARKER
You do understand now...words hold power. And sometimes that power is abused. You abused your power and you were wrong for that. You see?

JOHN
(unsure)
...Ok.

HARKER
Then let's move on, shall we?

JOHN
Please.

HARKER
Pick a file, please.

JOHN
The association test again?

HARKER
Yes, I thought it showed promise. Pick either.

John picks the one on his left. Harker picks it up. It's

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

images again.

HARKER
You remember the rules?

JOHN
You show me a word or picture and I tell you what I see. First thing that comes to mind.

HARKER
Very good. Let's begin.

Harker holds up the "obelisk" picture again.

HARKER
What is this?

John is confused for a moment then laughs a bit.

JOHN
I...still don't know what it's called. I still see a dagger.

Harker looks a bit frustrated. John notices.

Harker puts the image away and quickly puts on a phony smile.

HARKER
Of course.

INT. WELLNESS FACILITY

John leaves Harker's office and walks down a series of narrow blank hallways until he reaches a hall lined with doors. He enters his room.

INT. JOHN'S BEDROOM

A dim light illuminates John's corner of comfort in an otherwise empty room.

He is sitting on his thin mattress with a thin blanket and uncomfy pillow. There is a chair on the other side of the room as well as a small bookshelf that is mostly empty.

There is also an "OLIVE" ai unit in the wall.

John writes in his notebook. HIS HANDWRITING IS MESSY AND UNEVEN. We see that most of what he was writing was a letter of apology to principle Hart, but at the bottom it clearly

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

reads "Dr. Harker is weird.".

CUT TO.

John waking up in his room. He looks at his notebook and flips through the pages - he stops on the letter he wrote. It worked. He feels a bit better. He smiles.

An uplifting symphony plays as we follow John through his day.

MONTAGE OF:

John waits in line to shower and when he does we see there is a timer of 5:00 minutes counting down as he washes and once he is done there is a smiling worker waiting on the other side with a fresh folded pair of black clothes for him that he puts on.

John reading "Clone World" while he eats breakfast: a fruit crepe and a protein shake - as he reads a pair of other patients wearing identical clothes walk up to him and ask if they can sit to which John accepts. They all talk cordially.

John is in the "Exercise Room" in a sitting meditation pose with the rest of the patients ALL WEARING THE SAME CLOTHES. The instructor is the only one wearing anything different as she tells the patients to breathe. John breathes.

John walks out of the exercise room with a few other patients all laughing and talking, setting up plans to talk again soon before they split off to go do the next activity of the day.

John looks up at a nearby clock and sees that it is 1:58 and the clock is ticking fast - CLOSE UP ON CLOCK AS IT TICKS DOWN THE LAST 10 SECONDS TO 2:00.

INT. HARKER'S OFFICE

The symphony stops. It's silent except for the ticking by seconds.

CLOSE UP ON CLOCK IN THE LAST 5 SECONDS LEADING TO 2:00.

John is sitting across from Harker already. Neither of them are speaking.

Harker is staring at John while John tries to look anywhere else but Harker's eyes.

HARKER
Welcome back, John.

JOHN
Thank you, Dr. Harker. How are you doing today?

HARKER
John, I thought it was my job to ask you those questions.

JOHN
I mean...I guess so but I just wanted to-

HARKER
A joke. I'm doing quite well today. I helped myself to one of the crepes this morning, it really brightened my morning. You seem chipper today too.

JOHN
I am. Today has been good.

HARKER
(writing in notebook)
That's good to hear. The other day you seemed quite the oposite. What do you think changed from then to now?

JOHN
I really don't know. I didn't do much. I woke up feeling good, my shower was nice, it almost felt longer than 5 minutes, my clothes were warm, the crepes were nice, I talked with some of the other patients...even yoga was fun today.

HARKER
I'm very glad to hear that, John.

JOHN
Oh, I think I know what it was!

HARKER
Hm? Know what what was?

JOHN
What changed between yesterday and today. It's the smallest thing but I

just looked back in my journal, everything I wrote, and it was comforting. I was proud of everything I had done and everything I had said. I know it's only been a few days but I feel like my progress is going well, don't you?

HARKER
(writes in his notebook)
It certainly feels that way.

JOHN
Looks like I won't be seeing you for much longer.

HARKER
What do you mean?

JOHN
You helped me, I'm better. The results are...evident.
(John gestures to his smiling self)
And soon enough, I'll be heading home.

HARKER
(smiles)
We'll see.

John again looks confused but doesn't lose his smile.

Harker pulls the file of pictures out again. John recognizes it and is annoyed.

JOHN
You really like that exercise don't you?

HARKER
It's getting results. You just don't see them yet.

JOHN
I don't think I really need it, the notebook has been working fine.

HARKER
Then why don't we try it for fun, hm? Since soon enough, you'll be heading home.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JOHN
Sure.

HARKER
You remember the rules, I show you -

JOHN
I remember.

Harker and John go through a few images again - Harker shows images, John answers them.

Harker pulls out the picture of the obelisk again.

HARKER
Tell me what this is.

JOHN
(exasperated)
Again?

HARKER
Just answers, please.

JOHN
I don't know.

Harker writes in his notebook.

HARKER
I'm afraid that answer won't be acceptable any longer.

JOHN
Excuse me?

HARKER
Tell me what this is.

JOHN
I told you; I don't know. Can we move on from this, please?

HARKER
We aren't moving on until you give me an answer or until my shift is over. I can push my other sessions back.

John looks up at the clock. 2:02.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

JOHN
How am I supposed to magically learn the answer?

HARKER
It's been done before. Tell me what this is.

All the energy and enthusiasm John held today is knocked out of him.

MONTAGE OVER MUSIC

- THE CLOCK HITS 2:00 DAY AFTER DAY AND CONTINUES TO TICK BY FOR AN UNKNOWN LENGTH OF TIME

- HARKER PLANTING A RECORDING DEVICE AND RECITING THE SESSION NUMBERS (we get up to session 66)

- JOHN MEETS WITH HARKER WHO ASKS HIM ABOUT THE OBELISK. JOHN STILL DOESN'T KNOW WHAT IT IS

- JOHN'S BEARD GROWS BUT HARKER STAYS THE SAME

Interspliced with the montage are signs of John edging closer to a mental break:

- JOHN ASKS IF HARKER IS A REAL DOCTOR:

JOHN
Are you even a real doctor? All the therapists I know keep their doctorates on the wall, but you don't have *any* documents hanging *anywhere*! Nothing but that fucking painting!

- JOHN LOOKS THROUGH PUNCTUATION BOOKS IN THE LIBRARY TO TRY AND FIND THE OBELISK

- JOHN STANDS STILL DURING YOGA

- JOHN GETTING FRUSTRATED WITH HIMSELF IN HIS ROOM

- JOHN SITS ALONE AT BREAKFAST

- JOHN WRITES FRANTICALLY IN HIS NOTEBOOK. WE SEE SOME LINES:

"Harker is a fucking asshole." - "Harker is a liar." - "I'm not getting better." - "WHAT THE FUCK?!?!?"

INT. HARKER'S OFFICE

The clock ticks to 2:00.

John is already sitting across from Harker who is writing in his notebook. Harker's mug sits on the table.

John looks unkempt and tired. He now sports a shaggy full beard. He is not making eye contact with Harker. He is broken.

HARKER
How are we feeling today, John?

No response. Harker writes that down.

HARKER
You don't look too good today. Have you been sleeping?

Still no response. We hear the clock ticking.

HARKER
I can't help you if you don't talk to me, John.

JOHN
(weakly)
You don't want to help me.

HARKER
Tell me why you feel that way?

John looks up at Harker - they both know why he feels that way.

HARKER
Did you bring your notebook today like I asked?

John holds up his notebook.

HARKER
Great. Do you think you could read me an excerpt of one of your latest entries?

John opens his notebook to read. Everything he wrote is gone. A dozen or so pages have dated entries in them in SMALL NEAT HANDWRITING. The latest entry is for SESSION 30 and clearly reads at the bottom: "My sessions with Harker are working

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

wonderfully."

JOHN
No...I had everything, I kept track of everything. Why does it say session 30? We've been doing this for months.

HARKER
Actually, this session marks one month.

JOHN
Today is December 24th, I remember the dates, I kept track of everything. You're lying to me.

HARKER
Sometimes progress feels slow, but we're just about halfway through November. You might be out by Thanksgiving, if you're lucky.

JOHN
Therapy isn't about luck it's about helping people and you're not helping me!

HARKER
Please, John, bring down the tone. Read me something you wrote.

JOHN
(reading reluctantly)
"Today for breakfast we had Belgian waffles with butter, syrup, and fruit salad. It was delicious. I was a bit nervous to meet with Harker today but...after a little while, I became comfortable and excited to talk more. I'm starting to finally enjoy these association exercises. I think I'm getting really close to getting the answer. These sessions are really helping me..."

HARKER
I'm glad to see that you are starting to see the value in these exercises.

JOHN
Where are my notes? My real notes?

WRITTEN WORK OF COLTON RAY

HARKER
In your hand, in your heart, and in your mind. No one can take those away from you. Can they?

Harker smiles. If no one truly can take them, he's certainly trying to.

HARKER
Let's get started then, hm?

Harker pulls out the obelisk.

HARKER
Tell me what this is.

JOHN
Why are you playing with me?

Harker sighs, sets the picture down, and removes his glasses.

HARKER
You're right, John, I am playing with you and that's not fair. It's certainly not professional, and for that I apologize. Every time I let you walk out that door, I give you a false sense of hope that the next session might just be different, maybe better for you and your underdeveloped psyche. But it's going to be the same. It's always going to be the same until you get it right. You want to get it right too, I'm sure. You just can't. We don't even need the picture really, do we? You see it now, don't you? In your head? How long has it been burned in there? You still don't know what it is, do you? That must be irritating. Painful. Seeing something nonstop, not being able to get it out of your head and not knowing what it is. Like a bad song playing on loop. But it is for your betterment, I never lied to you about that. Olive?

OLIVE
Yes?

HARKER
Lights on, please.

Olive makes a confirmation sound and the "painting" on the wall blinks away to reveal a one-way mirror.

There is another doctor with another patient in the next room doing the same exercise as John and Harker. The patient is unaware that they are being watched.

JOHN
What...?

HARKER
Shh...watch.

DOCTOR
I know this one has been a bit of a struggle. What is this?

The doctor holds up a picture of the obelisk.

The patient hesitates for a moment, thinking hard to themself.

PATIENT
It's called an -

Harker throws his mug at John - it shatters loudly, overpowering the answer.

He runs to the mirror to try desperately to see if he can still hear what the other patient said. He is too late.

John slumps down...and picks up a shard of the broken mug.

DOCTOR
Correct, very good.

The doctor and patient continue in their session.

HARKER
Olive, that's enough. Thank you.

The mirror turns back into the painting.

HARKER
Have a seat, please.

John walks back to his chair and sits.

HARKER
That was the patient's 4th attempt with that particular exercise.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

Progress can be made, there is success to be achieved. You're just slow. For some reason, you and your tricky brain don't seem to want to get better. Why do you think that is?

No response.

HARKER
I see.

Harker holds up the picture of the obelisk.

John readies the mug shard he picked up.

John and Harker stare at each other for a moment. John with hatred, Harker with pride.

HARKER
(smiling)
Tell me what this is.

John lunges from his seat at the unphased doctor, holding the shard up high, about to plunge it into Harker's heart.

CUT TO BLACK.

THE END.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY